

TEMPLATE FOR RLA ARGUMENTATIVE ESSAY

The argument surrounding [Topic / Issue] is a multifaceted and highly debated issue with two distinct, conflicting viewpoints. While [Author A] explicitly argues that [Author A's main claim], the contrasting position held by [Author B] is significantly more compelling and intellectually rigorous. His/Her argument is inherently superior because it is firmly grounded in verifiable factual data and structured logical reasoning, whereas the opposing side relies heavily on manipulative emotional appeals and entirely unsubstantiated claims.

A primary reason [Author B] is more convincing is the strategic inclusion of credible, empirical evidence. For instance, the text explicitly mentions that [Specific Statistic / Factual Data from Author B]. This deliberate use of objective data successfully establishes a rock-solid logical foundation and strongly reinforces the overall validity of the author's claims by providing a concrete, measurable outcome. Furthermore, the author's exceptional ability to seamlessly link these specific statistics directly to the core argument makes their position feel deeply authoritative, well-researched, and completely logical, moving far beyond mere personal opinion to scientific probability.

In stark contrast, the argument provided by [Author A] is significantly weaker and unpersuasive because it completely lacks the necessary quantitative data to justify its broad assertions. While she/he suggests that [Author A's weak anecdotal point / example], this weak assertion is based entirely on subjective personal anecdotes rather than objective statistical proof. This represents a major logical fallacy, as a single case study possesses an incredibly limited sample size and utterly fails to prove a universal, widespread trend. Without concrete evidence, peer-reviewed data, or expert testimony, her/his argument fundamentally fails to build a persuasive case. Consequently, when directly compared to the data-driven approach of [Author B], [Author A]'s position remains less reliable and entirely lacks intellectual and logical depth.

In conclusion, while both passages extensively address the issue, [Author B] offers a far more effectively supported and persuasive argument. His/Her position relies on a highly coherent logical structure and concrete factual evidence that the opposing side consistently fails to provide. Because it is thoroughly well-supported and actively avoids the inherent bias of casual personal observation, this position undeniably stands as the more persuasive viewpoint.

EXAMPLE

Example Question

Passage 1: The Circadian Advantage

By Wabi

"Modern society often glorifies the night owl lifestyle, but our biology tells a completely different story. Human beings are fundamentally governed by a circadian rhythm that thrives on early sleep patterns. When we align our rest with the natural setting of the sun, our bodies undergo deep cellular repair that cannot be replicated during daytime sleep. In fact, a recent landmark study tracking over 5,000 adults revealed that sleeping early decreases biological aging by up to 40% over a ten-year period. This measurable reduction in cellular stress underscores why a structured, early sleep schedule is a biological necessity rather than a personal preference. Failing to prioritize these early hours compromises the body's immune defenses and accelerates long-term decline."

Passage 2: The Myth of the Early Bird

By Lara

"For decades, we have been told that the only way to be healthy and productive is to sleep early and wake up at dawn. However, this rigid mindset completely ignores individual differences. Sleeping late doesn't cause any harmful effects as long as an individual gets a consistent, sufficient amount of total sleep hours. For example, look at my father. He has worked as a late-night freelance designer for over thirty years, rarely going to bed before 3:00 AM. Despite his unconventional schedule, he looks incredibly young, has endless energy, and outperforms people half his age at the gym. Forcing everyone into a morning-person mold is unnecessary; our bodies adapt perfectly fine to the schedules that best fit our unique lives and professions."

Answer of the Example Question (Memorize This)

The argument surrounding [sleeping early versus late] is a multifaceted and highly debated issue with two distinct, conflicting viewpoints. While [Lara] explicitly argues that [sleeping late doesn't cause any harmful effect], the contrasting position held by [Wabi] is significantly more compelling and intellectually rigorous. [His] argument is inherently superior because it is firmly grounded in verifiable factual data and structured logical reasoning, whereas the opposing side relies heavily on manipulative emotional appeals and entirely unsubstantiated claims.

A primary reason [Wabi] is more convincing is the strategic inclusion of credible, empirical evidence. For instance, the text explicitly mentions that [sleeping early decreases aging by 40%]. This deliberate use of objective data successfully establishes a rock-solid logical foundation and strongly reinforces the overall validity of the author's claims by providing a concrete, measurable outcome. Furthermore, the author's exceptional ability to seamlessly link these specific statistics directly to the core argument makes their position feel deeply authoritative, well-researched, and completely logical, moving far beyond mere personal opinion to scientific probability.

In stark contrast, the argument provided by [Lara] is significantly weaker and unpersuasive because it completely lacks the necessary quantitative data to justify its broad assertions. While she suggests that [her father sleeps late but still looks young], this weak assertion is based entirely on subjective personal anecdotes rather than objective statistical proof. This represents a major logical fallacy, as a single case study possesses an incredibly limited sample size and utterly fails to prove a universal, widespread trend. Without concrete evidence, peer-reviewed data, or expert testimony, [her] argument fundamentally fails to build a persuasive case. Consequently, when directly compared to the data-driven approach of [Wabi], [Lara's] position remains less reliable and entirely lacks intellectual and logical depth.

In conclusion, while both passages extensively address the issue, [Wabi] offers a far more effectively supported and persuasive argument. [His] position relies on a highly coherent logical structure and concrete factual evidence that the opposing side consistently fails to provide. Because it is thoroughly well-supported and actively avoids the inherent bias of casual personal observation, this position undeniably stands as the more persuasive viewpoint.

GED STYLE QUESTIONS

GED RLA Extended Response Practice Question 1

Essay Question

Analyze both passages and determine which argument is better supported. Use evidence and reasoning from the passages to support your response.

Passage 1

Written by The National Student Health Foundation

For decades, schools across the country have started classes very early in the morning, with many students required to arrive before 7:30 a.m. However, recent scientific research strongly suggests that later school start times provide major benefits for students academically, emotionally, and physically.

According to a nationwide study conducted by the National Sleep Research Center, teenagers naturally experience changes in their biological sleep cycles during adolescence. Because of these changes, most teenagers struggle to fall asleep before 11:00 p.m. As a result, students who must wake up extremely early often fail to receive the recommended eight to ten hours of sleep necessary for healthy brain function.

The consequences of sleep deprivation among students are serious. Researchers found that schools that delayed start times by at least one hour experienced a 20% increase in student attendance and significantly improved test scores. In addition, students reported lower stress levels and better concentration during class. Medical professionals have also linked lack of sleep in teenagers to depression, anxiety, obesity, and weakened immune systems.

Critics sometimes argue that later start times would interfere with sports schedules or after-school jobs. However, schools in several states have already adopted later schedules successfully. In many cases, schools adjusted athletic programs without major difficulty. Parents also reported that their children became more energetic, motivated, and emotionally stable after receiving more sleep.

Supporters of later start times believe schools should prioritize students' health and learning above outdated scheduling traditions. Given the growing amount of scientific evidence supporting later start times, many experts argue that continuing extremely early school schedules ignores both medical research and students' well-being.

Passage 2

Written by Principal Karen Mitchell

While some researchers support later school start times, changing school schedules would create more problems than benefits for students, parents, and communities. Traditional school schedules have existed for generations because they allow schools and families to function efficiently.

One major issue with later start times is transportation. Many school districts operate on limited budgets and share buses between elementary, middle, and high schools. Delaying high school start times could force districts to purchase additional buses and hire more drivers, creating unnecessary financial strain. Taxpayers would likely be responsible for these increased costs.

Additionally, after-school activities would become more difficult to manage. Student athletes could miss more class time when traveling to games, especially during winter months when daylight ends earlier. Students who work part-time jobs after school might also struggle to balance employment, homework, and extracurricular activities if school ended later in the evening.

Supporters of later start times often assume students would simply sleep more. However, many teenagers already spend excessive time on phones, video games, and social media late at night. Delaying school schedules may encourage students to stay awake even longer rather than improve sleeping habits. Parents should teach teenagers responsibility and proper time management instead of expecting schools to solve the issue through scheduling changes.

Furthermore, schools are designed not only for education but also to prepare students for adulthood. Many careers require adults to wake up early and follow demanding schedules. Learning discipline and responsibility at a young age can help students develop habits necessary for future success.

Although later start times may sound appealing, maintaining traditional schedules provides stability and practicality for schools and communities. Instead of restructuring entire school systems, families and students should focus on improving personal habits and reducing distractions before bedtime.

GED RLA Extended Response Practice

Question 2

Essay Question

Analyze both passages and determine which argument is better supported. Use evidence and reasoning from the passages to support your response.

Passage 1

Written by The Environmental Action Coalition

In recent years, many cities around the world have begun banning single-use plastic products such as plastic bags, straws, cups, and food containers. Environmental experts argue these bans are necessary because plastic pollution has become one of the largest environmental problems facing the planet today.

According to research published by the Oceanic Conservation Institute, millions of tons of plastic waste enter oceans every year. Since plastic does not easily decompose, it can remain in the environment for hundreds of years. Marine animals frequently mistake plastic for food, leading to injury, starvation, and death. Scientists have discovered plastic particles inside fish, sea turtles, and even drinking water used by humans.

Supporters of plastic bans also argue that single-use plastics encourage a wasteful culture. Many plastic items are used for only a few minutes before being thrown away permanently. Cities that introduced plastic bag bans reportedly reduced street litter and landfill waste significantly within just a few years. In some communities, reusable bags and biodegradable products became increasingly affordable as demand grew.

In addition to environmental benefits, advocates claim plastic bans encourage innovation. Businesses have started developing paper-based packaging, compostable containers, and reusable alternatives that create less long-term waste. Supporters believe these changes can help protect future generations from worsening pollution and environmental destruction.

Although critics argue plastic products are convenient and inexpensive, environmental groups believe convenience should not outweigh environmental responsibility. They maintain that governments must take action now before pollution levels become even more dangerous and costly to address in the future.

Passage 2

Written by Restaurant Owner Daniel Harper

While environmental protection is important, banning single-use plastics is an unrealistic solution that creates unnecessary problems for businesses and consumers. Plastic products remain popular because they are affordable, practical, and widely accessible.

For many small businesses, especially restaurants and food delivery services, switching to environmentally friendly alternatives can be extremely expensive. Biodegradable containers and paper packaging often cost significantly more than plastic products. Small businesses already operating on tight budgets may struggle to absorb these increased expenses, forcing some owners to raise prices or reduce staff.

Plastic alternatives may also be less effective in certain situations. Paper straws quickly become soggy, reusable bags require cleaning, and some biodegradable products still require special processing facilities unavailable in many cities. Critics argue that banning plastics before reliable and affordable alternatives are fully developed places an unfair burden on businesses and consumers.

Additionally, some opponents believe the real problem is not plastic itself, but poor waste management and irresponsible behavior. They argue governments should focus on improving recycling systems, increasing public education, and enforcing anti-littering laws instead of banning products people use daily. Many plastic items can already be recycled when disposed of properly.

Critics also worry that government bans reduce personal freedom by limiting consumer choices. Rather than allowing individuals and businesses to decide what products work best for them, these laws force everyone to follow the same restrictions regardless of their circumstances.

Although reducing pollution is an important goal, opponents of plastic bans believe practical solutions such as better recycling and public responsibility would be more effective than strict government regulations.
